

Subdivision Lesson One:

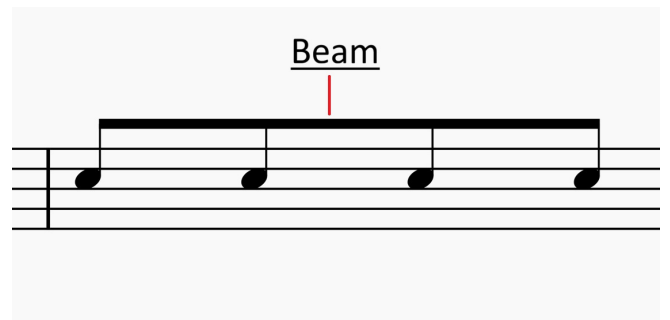
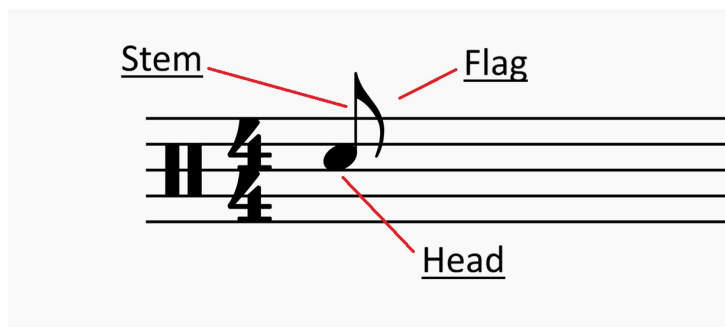
Eighth Notes

Jacobo Vega-Albela

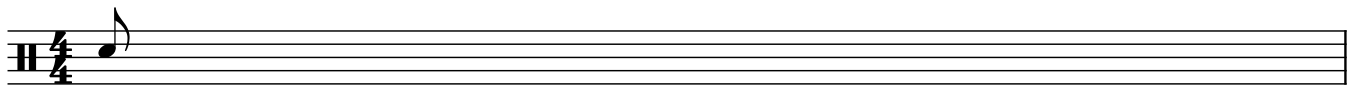
What is subdivision?

Subdivision occurs when the beats of the pulse are split up into smaller units. In order to understand subdivision, we must first look at the parts of a written note.

The notes in the diagram below have three parts: the **note head**, which tells us to play (one note head equals one attack), the **stem**, which is the vertical line coming out of the note head, and the **flag**: a new element we have not seen before in our studies of quarter notes! The **flag** serves a very specific purpose: it **doubles the speed** of the note it is attached to. We can rephrase this a different way: the flag cuts the length of the note in half. When two or more notes with flags are placed next to each other, the flags will often be combined into a **beam**.



The notes in the diagram above are called **eighth notes**. Notice, they resemble quarter notes, but with an added **flag** or **beam**. The function of the **flag** or beam is to cut the note length in half, making it twice as fast. Some more examples of eighth notes in different groupings are included below:



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Let's review a few ideas.

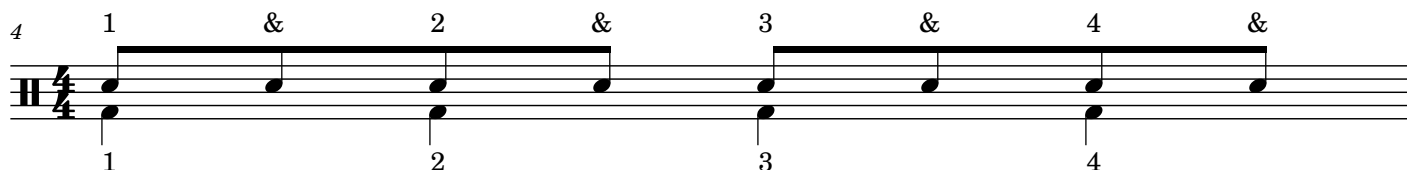
- In 4/4 time, we have four beats in each measure.
- Each of those beats is one quarter note long.
- Eighth notes are twice as fast as quarter notes.

So, we can fit **two eighth notes** into each **beat** in our measure, for a total of **eight eighth notes**.

In our counting system, we always use the numbers to mark the **beats** of our **pulse**. Each subdivision gets its own non-number syllable, in the case of eighth notes we use "and", often written as + or &.

In the example below we have **two voices**. The bottom voice plays quarter notes, while the top voice plays eighths.

Counts are written in to help you visualize the relationship here.



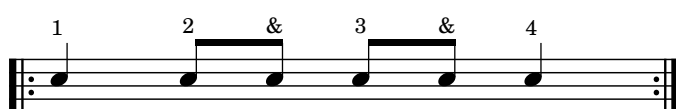
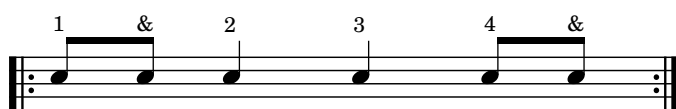
Now our eighth notes written on a single line with no second voice:



And now some examples of quarter note and eighth note mixture. It is **very important to remember** that the **eighth notes** are **twice as fast** as the **quarter notes**. This means the quarters should feel **long** while the eighths should feel **short**. Practice these with a metronome at 60bpm with beat one accent on. Try this with, and without eighth note subdivision enabled. You can follow the link or scan the QR code below for a metronome pre-set to 60bpm with beat one accent, and eighth note subdivision enabled:

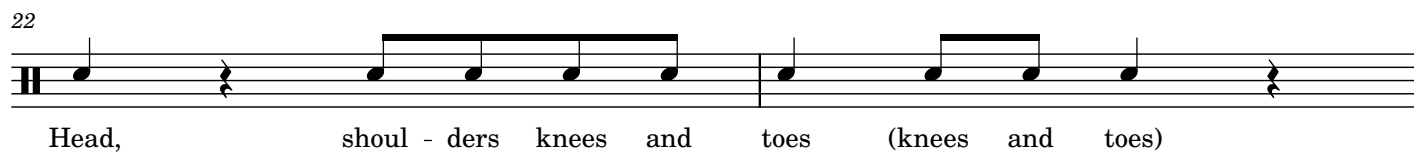
<https://jva-music.com/metronome/?bpm=60&beats=4&unit=4&p=ANNN&sub=2>





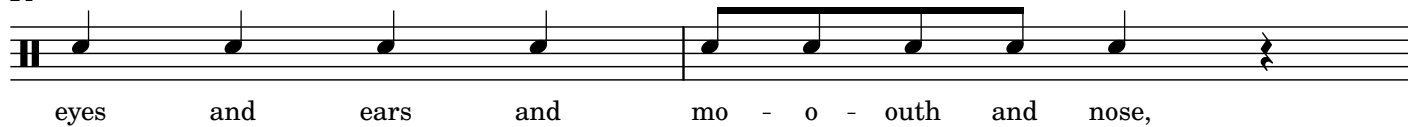
Now for some more famous melodies to encourage **audiation**. Once again, no counts are written, but you can write them in for yourself if you find it helpful

Head, Shoulders, Knees And Toes

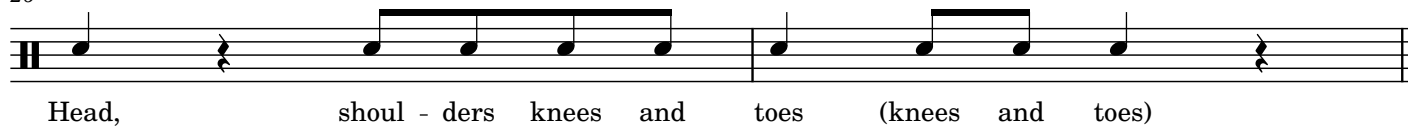


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24



26



Rain, Rain, Go Away

28



30



Theme from "Can-Can" (Galop Infernal by Jacques Offenbach)

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